

EUANGELION

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Saved & Faithing — Deep Dive

*This is the master "Deep Dive" document for **Saved & Faithing**, a seven-day immersion in **John 3:1–21**.*

For a single hour, you can read this whole thing and have the week. For a single minute, scroll to the verses, then to the closing. Everything in between is here when you are.

The Question, By Night

A Pharisee comes to Jesus **νυκτὶ** (*nukti*) — by night. He is named: Nicodemus. He is a teacher of Israel, a member of the ruling council. He has a reputation to protect. He has questions he cannot ask in daylight.

Most of Christianity begins this way. Not in the public confession. Not at the altar call. Not in the swelling chorus. It begins in some small, private room where someone who has more to lose than to gain sits across from Jesus and says, in effect, *I cannot quite ask this out loud yet*.

The whole conversation in John 3:1–21 — twenty-one verses that contain John 3:16, the most-read verse in Christianity — happens because one careful, frightened, brilliant man came in the dark. **The good news is that Jesus did not turn him away for it.**

What Jesus said to him in those verses contains everything the church has ever fought about: salvation, faith, baptism, the Spirit, the cross, the world, light and darkness. We will spend seven days inside this passage. This document is the whole map.

The Cosmic Frame: John 3 in the Gospel of John

John's Gospel is built like a cathedral. The opening is a prologue (1:1–18) — *"In the beginning was the Word... and the Word became flesh."* That sets the cosmic stage. Then John the Baptist testifies (1:19–34). The first disciples are called (1:35–51). At Cana, water becomes wine (2:1–11). Jesus cleanses the temple (2:13–22).

Then chapter 3.

This is the first sustained teaching dialogue in John. It is not delivered to a crowd. It is delivered to one man, alone, at night. The Gospel writer is making a structural claim: **before Jesus speaks publicly to the world, He speaks privately to a teacher of Israel about being born again, about water and Spirit, about the Son of Man lifted up, about God's love for the world.** Everything that comes after — every miracle, every "I am" saying, every confrontation with the religious establishment, every word from the cross — is unfolded from the seed planted in this conversation.

The chapter has three movements:

- **3:1–8** — *Born from above, born of water and Spirit.* Jesus' opening claim and Nicodemus's first failure to understand.
- **3:9–15** — *How can these things be?* The pivot from confusion to revelation, climaxing in the bronze-serpent typology.
- **3:16–21** — *God so loved the world.* The cosmic theological summary: love, sending, belief, salvation, light, judgment.

These three movements are the architecture of the seven days.

Day-by-Day Walk Through John 3:1–21

3:1–2 — The One Who Came at Night

"Now there was a Pharisee, a man named Nicodemus who was a member of the Jewish ruling council. He came to Jesus at night and said, 'Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher who has come from God. For no one could perform the signs you are doing if God were not with him.'" — John 3:1–2 (NIV)

Nicodemus opens with credentials, his and Jesus's. He represents *we* — *we know* — likely meaning a quiet contingent of the council who has watched Jesus and concluded something. He calls Him *Rabbi*. He calls Him a *teacher who has come from God*. He affirms the signs. **Everything he says is true. None of it is enough.**

Jesus does not return the courtesy. He does not say, "Thank you, Nicodemus, for your generous assessment." He cuts past it. The night-coming earnestness deserves more than confirmation; it deserves the truth.

3:3 — Born From Above

"Jesus replied, 'Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.'" — John 3:3 (NIV)

The Greek phrase is γεννηθῆ ἀνωθεν (*gennēthē anōthen*) — and *anōthen* carries two meanings simultaneously: *again* and *from above*. Translators must pick one. Jesus meant both. Nicodemus, hearing only *again*, responds with the obvious physical absurdity (3:4): *Surely they cannot enter a second time into their mother's womb to be born!* He is not stupid. He is hearing the lower of the two meanings because the higher one is too much.

To be born *from above* is to receive a life that does not come from below. Nothing the council can confer, no genealogy, no Torah-credential, no Pharisee-discipline produces it. Jesus is

saying: *the kingdom of God is not extended to those who climb up to it; it is given to those who are born down into it from above.*

3:5–8 — Of Water and Spirit

"Jesus answered, 'Very truly I tell you, no one can enter the kingdom of God unless they are born of water and the Spirit. Flesh gives birth to flesh, but the Spirit gives birth to spirit. You should not be surprised at my saying, 'You must be born again.' The wind blows wherever it pleases. You hear its sound, but you cannot tell where it comes from or where it is going. So it is with everyone born of the Spirit.'" — John 3:5–8 (NIV)

The Greek here puts a single word in the place of three English ones: *πνεῦμα* (*pneuma*). It means *breath, wind, Spirit*. Its Hebrew sister, *רוּחַ* (*ruach*), behaves the same way. *Ruach* is the wind that hovers over the waters in Genesis 1:2. *Ruach* is the breath that animates the dust-Adam in Genesis 2:7. *Ruach* is the wind that breathes life into the dry bones in Ezekiel 37. Jesus uses one word with all three meanings at once. When He says *the wind blows where it pleases*, He is saying *the Spirit moves where the Spirit moves*. The Spirit's movement is sovereign — heard, not steered.

Born of water and the Spirit. Two readings have lived side by side in faithful Christian interpretation for two thousand years. The first hears Ezekiel 36:25–27 — *"I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean... I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you"* — and reads water and Spirit as one cleansing-and-renewal act, the new covenant that the prophets foresaw. The second hears the sacrament — Christian baptism, water joined with Spirit, the visible sign of the invisible birth. Both readings are inside the text. Both have shaped real Christian lives. The passage does not arbitrate between them; it holds them.

3:9–13 — How Can These Things Be?

"How can this be?" Nicodemus asked. 'You are Israel's teacher,' said Jesus, 'and do you not understand these things? Very truly I tell you, we speak of what we know,

and we testify to what we have seen, but still you people do not accept our testimony. I have spoken to you of earthly things and you do not believe; how then will you believe if I speak of heavenly things? No one has ever gone into heaven except the one who came from heaven – the Son of Man.” – John 3:9–13 (NIV)

This is the pivot of the conversation, and the structural pivot of our seven days. Nicodemus has met the limit of what *understanding* can produce. The question *how can this be?* is not a request for one more diagram. It is the moment a brilliant man recognizes that the next step is not another step of the mind.

What is asked of him next is a verb. The Greek is πιστεύω (*pisteuō*) – to trust, to entrust, to believe. It is present-active-indicative across this passage: continuous trust, not a one-time mental assent. English flattened *faith* into a noun on a shelf; Greek and Hebrew never did. The Hebrew אֱמוּנָה (*emunah*) – *steadfast faithfulness* – is the same kind of verb-shaped word. In Habakkuk 2:4: “*the righteous person will live by his faithfulness.*” In Romans 1:17, Paul reaches back through the Septuagint to that same Hebrew word and lands the New Testament’s central claim: “*the righteous will live by faith.*”

What Nicodemus is being asked for is not certainty. It is *faithing*. The verb steps off the cliff. The noun stays on the shelf. The Israelite teacher who has been climbing the ladder of understanding is being asked to step off it – to trust before the data closes, to entrust himself to the Son of Man who descended from heaven precisely so that he would not have to ascend.

3:14–15 – Lifted Up Like the Serpent

“Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness, so the Son of Man must be lifted up, that everyone who believes may have eternal life in him.” – John 3:14–15 (NIV)

The Greek is ὑψωθῆναι (*hupsōthēnai*) – *to be lifted up*. John uses it three more times in his Gospel (8:28, 12:32, 12:34), and each time it means both *crucified* and *exalted* at the same

time. The cross is not a humiliation followed by a glorification; the cross *is* the glorification. The lifting is one motion.

The reference is Numbers 21:6–9. Israel grumbles in the wilderness. Venomous snakes come into the camp; people are bitten and die. Moses prays. God instructs him to make a bronze serpent and lift it up on a pole. *Anyone who is bitten can look at it and live.* It is not an antidote that is given. It is something to be looked at. The wound stays. The poison still moves through the body. But the one who looks up lives.

This is what Jesus says about Himself. He will be lifted up. Those who look — who *trust*, who *faith* — will not perish. Notice: He does not say *those who look will be uncomplicated.* Notice: He does not say *those who look will be unwounded.* He says they will not perish. They will have eternal life.

This is also the moment the **death-baptism** of the gospel comes into view. To be raised with Christ, you must first be buried with Him; to be exalted, you must first be lifted onto the cross-shaped staff. Romans 6:5: *"For if we have been united with him in a death like his, we will certainly also be united with him in a resurrection like his."* The bronze serpent is the seed. The cross is the tree. Romans 6 is the harvest.

3:16–17 — God So Loved the World

"For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life. For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through him." — John 3:16–17 (NIV)

The Greek is τὸν κόσμον (*ton kosmon*) — *the world*. Not the church. Not the elect (in this verse). Not the one nation. *Kosmos* — the whole ordered creation, including the parts that do not love Him back. *Houtōs gar ēgāpēsen ho theos ton kosmon — for in this manner God loved the world.* The *manner* of the love is what is described next: He *gave* (ἔδωκεν, *edōken*). The cross is the manner of the love.

And the verb that follows, four times in two verses: πιστεύων (*pisteuōn*), πιστεύῃ (*pisteuē*), πιστεύων (*pisteuōn*)

again. The whoever-believes is grammatically the *one-who-is-faithing*. Continuous, present, active. Salvation is not a transaction completed in 3:16; it is a life lived in the verb of 3:16.

The Greek for *saved* is σωθῆναι (sōthē) — from σῶζω (sōzō), the same word the Gospels use for healing the sick, calming the storm, raising the dead, forgiving sin. Jesus does not save out of the world; He saves *the world*. The whole damaged ordered thing.

3:18–21 — Light Has Come

"Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe stands condemned already because they have not believed in the name of God's one and only Son. This is the verdict: Light has come into the world, but people loved darkness instead of light because their deeds were evil. Everyone who does evil hates the light, and will not come into the light for fear that their deeds will be exposed. But whoever lives by the truth comes into the light, so that it may be seen plainly that what they have done has been done in the sight of God." — John 3:18–21 (NIV)

The Greek is φῶς (phōs) — *light*. Phōs echoes Genesis 1:3 — *"Let there be light."* It echoes John 1:4 — *"In him was life, and that life was the light of all mankind."* It is the same light. The Word who spoke creation into being is the Light who has come into the world. The one who came at night to ask Jesus a question is being told that the light has stepped into the dark.

The verdict (Greek κρίσις, krisis — *crisis, judgment, separation*) is not pronounced on the world. The verdict is the light. The world's response to the light is what the verdict reveals. Those whose deeds cannot bear examination flee. Those who *do truth* — Greek ποιῶν τὴν ἀλήθειαν (poiōn tēn alētheian) — *come into the light*. Notice: they are described not as those who *believe* the truth but as those who *do* it. *Faithing*, again, in verb form. Truth is something embodied, walked into, done.

The conversation that opened *by night* closes with light. The man who came in the dark is being asked to step into a

different dark — the dark before dawn — and walk toward the light that has come.

Reading Through PaRDeS: The Four Levels of Interpretation

The ancient rabbis taught that Scripture has four levels of meaning, captured in the acronym **PaRDeS** (פרדס, *pardes*, "orchard"): *Peshat*, *Remez*, *Derash*, *Sod*. John 3:1–21 unfolds at all four.

Peshat (פשוט) — The Plain Meaning

A man named Nicodemus came to Jesus at night, called Him a teacher, and was told he must be born again, of water and Spirit. He did not understand. Jesus told him about the bronze serpent in Numbers 21 and said the Son of Man must be lifted up the same way. God loved the world enough to send His Son to save it. Light has come into the world.

That is the plain reading. Already enough for a lifetime.

Remez (רמז) — The Hint

The text *hints* at deeper truths. *Anōthen* — the word for *again* — also means *from above*, hinting that the new birth is not a repetition but a descent of life from God. *Pneuma* — the word for *Spirit* — also means *breath* and *wind*, hinting that the Spirit's movement is the same act as God's breath in Genesis 2:7 and the wind that sweeps over the waters in Genesis 1:2. *Hupsōthēnai* — the word for *lifted up* — hints at both crucifixion and exaltation in a single motion. The hints are the rabbi's pointing finger: look closer.

Derash (דרש) — The Search

What does it mean for *us* to be born from above? What does it mean to *come into the light*? *Derash* is the level where the text becomes personal. Nicodemus is not just a first-century Pharisee. He is the part of every reader who has more to lose than to gain. He is the careful self that comes by night. The new

birth is not just a doctrine; it is the door he is being asked to walk through.

The bronze serpent is not just an Old Testament curiosity. It is the answer to *what do I do with what is killing me?* You look up. You faith. You do not earn your way out. You do not understand your way out. You look.

***Sod* (סוד) — The Secret**

This is the level of mystery, the prophetic and typological reading. The bronze serpent on the staff *is* the cross before the cross. The water-and-Spirit *is* the Genesis 1:2 *ruach* hovering over the chaos before the world began. The light coming into the world *is* the Word who was *in the beginning* (John 1:1) and through whom all things were made. The whole conversation in John 3 is the unveiling of a pattern that was always there, woven through the whole canon — a *sod* hidden in the structure of Scripture itself.

When we read the text at all four levels, we see that John 3:1–21 is not just one conversation in one Gospel. It is the seed that contains the whole tree.

Hebrew & Greek

A reader who knows the original-language words will see the conversation differently. Wherever Greek or Hebrew appears, the transliteration appears beside it.

***Nukti* (νυκτι) — By Night**

Dative singular of νύξ (*nyx*). It is the *time* in which Nicodemus comes. John uses it twice more in his Gospel: when Jesus calls Judas's betrayal "and it was night" (13:30), and when Mary Magdalene comes to the empty tomb "while it was still dark" (20:1). The night is John's signature for the moment something secret is moving — for good or for ill.

Gennēthē Anōthen (γεννηθῆ ἄνωθεν) – Born From Above / Born Again

Gennēthē – aorist passive subjunctive of γεννάω (*gennaō*) – *to be born*. *Anōthen* – *from above* (its primary meaning) and *again* (its secondary meaning). The double sense is deliberate. Jesus does not pick one. The new birth is *both* a fresh start *and* a descent from God. To be born again is to be born *from above*.

Pneuma (πνεῦμα) ↔ Ruach (רוּחַ) – Breath, Wind, Spirit

One word in Greek; one word in Hebrew. Both languages refuse to separate breath from wind from Spirit. Genesis 1:2: *ruach Elohim* – *the Spirit of God* – moved over the waters. Genesis 2:7: God breathed (*ruach*) the breath of life into the dust – Adam. Ezekiel 37: the *ruach* came into the slain, and they lived. John 3:8: *the wind (pneuma) blows where it pleases*. John 20:22: Jesus *breathed (enephusēsen) on them and said, 'Receive the Holy Spirit (Pneuma).'* Same word. Same act, finally completed.

Pisteuō (πιστεύω) – To Trust, To Faith

Present active. Continuous. The salvation language of John 3 is verb-language. *Whoever-is-faithing* will not perish. Faith is not a state you arrive at; it is a posture you keep. The Hebrew sister word is אמן (*aman*), which gives us *amen (āmēn)* – *let it be true* – and אמונה (*emunah*), *faithfulness, steadfastness*. To faith is to keep saying *amen* with your whole life.

Hupsōthēnai (ὑψοθῆναι) – To Be Lifted Up

Aorist passive infinitive of ὑψόω (*hupsoō*). In John, it means crucifixion and exaltation at once. The lifting up of the Son of Man is the bronze serpent on the staff (Numbers 21), the cross on the hill (John 19), and the seating at the right hand of the Father (Acts 2:33) – one continuous motion. The lifting is the saving.

Sōzō (σώζω) – To Save

The Gospels use this verb for healing the sick, calming the storm, raising the dead, forgiving sin. Salvation in the New

Testament is not flat. It is whole. *Sōzō* covers the whole rescue: deliverance from peril, restoration to wholeness, ongoing safekeeping. John 3:17: *that the world through him might be saved* — *sōthē* — same root.

***Phōs* (φῶς) — Light**

The first word God speaks in Genesis 1:3, *Yhi or* — "Let there be light" — is *phōs* in the Septuagint. The light John says has *come into the world* (3:19) is the same light God spoke at the beginning. The light is not a metaphor. The light is a person. *Phōs* is the verdict on every dark conversation.

***Emunah* (אֱמוּנָה) — Faithfulness, Steadfastness**

The Hebrew word behind Habakkuk 2:4 — *the righteous shall live by emunah*. Paul reaches back to this word in Romans 1:17. To *faith*e is to live by *emunah* — to be steady in the trust over time. *Emunah* gives English the word *amen*. To say *amen* is to say *I trust*. To live by *emunah* is to keep saying *amen* with the body.

Old Testament Roots

John 3 is not a stand-alone teaching. It is a knot tying four Old Testament strands together.

Genesis 1:2 — The *Ruach* Over the Waters

"Now the earth was formless and empty, darkness was over the surface of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters." — Genesis 1:2 (NIV)

The first thing the Bible tells us about creation, after the formlessness, is that the *ruach* — the Spirit, the breath, the wind — was *hovering*. The Hebrew verb רָחַף (*rachaph*) is rare; it appears in Deuteronomy 32:11 of an eagle hovering over its young. The Spirit is brooding over the chaos *before* anything is made. When Jesus says, in John 3:5–8, that the new birth is *of water and the Spirit*, He is reaching back to this

verse. New creation looks like first creation: the *ruach* hovers, water is present, life comes.

Numbers 21:6–9 — The Bronze Serpent

"Then the LORD sent venomous snakes among them; they bit the people and many Israelites died... The LORD said to Moses, 'Make a snake and put it up on a pole; anyone who is bitten can look at it and live.'" —
Numbers 21: 6, 8 (NIV)

This is the OT root Jesus names *explicitly* in John 3:14. The bronze serpent is not the antidote; it is the sign. The bite still hurts. The poison still moves. But those who look, live. The sign is the gospel before the gospel: salvation by looking up at what was lifted up. Romans 6 fulfills this in baptism — buried with Christ, raised with Him.

Ezekiel 36:25–27 — Clean Water, New Spirit

"I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean; I will cleanse you from all your impurities and from all your idols. I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you; I will remove from you your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees and be careful to keep my laws." — *Ezekiel 36: 25–27 (NIV)*

The clearest OT background to John 3:5. *Water and Spirit*, paired, in the language of new-covenant promise. Ezekiel's prophecy is the well from which Jesus draws when He tells Nicodemus what the kingdom-entrance looks like. A first-century rabbi would have heard the echo.

Habakkuk 2:4 — Live by *Emunah*

"See, the enemy is puffed up; his desires are not upright — but the righteous person will live by his faithfulness." — *Habakkuk 2: 4 (NIV)*

The single Old Testament verse Paul quotes in Romans 1:17 to anchor the gospel. *The righteous will live by emunah* — by

faithfulness, by steady trust over time. John 3's *whoever-is-faithing* is the New Testament's continuous-present recovery of Habakkuk's *emunah*.

New Testament Echoes

The conversation in John 3 echoes through the rest of the New Testament.

- **Romans 6:3–5** — *"Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death? We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death."* This is the *hupsōthēnai* of John 3:14 worked out into the disciple's body. Lifted up with Him; buried with Him; raised with Him.
- **Titus 3:5** — *"He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit."* The washing-of-rebirth language is Pauline shorthand for John 3:5. *Water and Spirit* compressed into one phrase.
- **1 Peter 1:23** — *"For you have been born again, not of perishable seed, but of imperishable, through the living and enduring word of God."* Peter's gloss on John 3:3. The new birth is from imperishable seed — from above.
- **Colossians 1:13** — *"For he has rescued us from the dominion of darkness and brought us into the kingdom of the Son he loves."* The light/darkness ending of John 3 made into the church's confession.
- **Ephesians 5:8** — *"For you were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Live as children of light."* The closing of John 3:21 — *whoever lives by the truth comes into the light* — turned into a charge.

These are not loose associations. They are the same conversation continuing inside the New Testament's own bloodstream.

One Conversation, Seven Doors

Seven days. One passage. One conversation, by night, between a careful man and the Light Himself. Each daily opens a door into a different room of this one conversation. Together, they form the house.

- **Day 1** — *Nicodemus by Night*. The secret seekers among us.
- **Day 2** — *Born From Above*. The descent of life that is not earned.
- **Day 3** — *Of Water and Spirit*. The wind that blows where it wills.
- **Day 4** — *How Can These Things Be?* Faithing beneath knowing.
- **Day 5** — *Lifted Up*. The bronze serpent and the cross.
- **Day 6** — *God So Loved*. The cosmic scope of the rescue.
- **Day 7** — *Light Has Come*. Stepping into the dawn.

If you have an hour, read this whole document and you have the week. If you have ten minutes, pick one verse and stay there. If you have one minute, read 3:16 again and let it land. The whole house is here when you are.

References

[1] *The Gospel of John (NIV)*, John 3:1–21. Biblica, 2011. [2] *The Gospel of John (Greek New Testament, UBS5)*. United Bible Societies, 5th ed., 2014. [3] *The Hebrew Bible (BHS)*, Habakkuk 2:4; Numbers 21:6–9; Genesis 1:2; Ezekiel 36:25–27. Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. [4] N. T. Wright, *John for Everyone, Part One: Chapters 1–10*, (Westminster John Knox Press, 2004), commentary on John 3. [5] D. A. Carson, *The Gospel According to John*, (Pillar New Testament Commentary; Eerdmans, 1991), commentary on John 3. [6] BibleProject, "John (Series Overview)" and "Holy Spirit." bibleproject.com. [7] Andreas J. Köstenberger, *John* (Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament; Baker Academic, 2004), pp. 117–146. [8] *Theological Dictionary of the New Testament (TDNT)*, Kittel & Friedrich, eds. — entries on *pisteuō*, *anōthen*, *hupsoō*, *sōzō*, *phōs*.

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